

4.2.1 Elements of crime writing

In the case of Elements of crime writing, many of the texts pre-date the crime fiction genre that emerged as a recognisable literary genre in the mid-19th century and with academic recognition in the 20th century. However, in all the texts a significant crime drives the narrative and the execution and consequences of the crime are fundamentally important to the way the text is structured.

All set texts are narratives which focus on transgressions against established order and the specific breaking of either national, social, religious or moral laws. The focus in this component must be on 'Elements' and students need to consider the elements that exist in each of their texts. The elements that might be explored, depending on the individual text, include:

- the type of the crime text itself, whether it is detective fiction, a post-modern novel, a revenge tragedy, an account of a life lost to crime
- the settings that are created as backdrops for criminal action and for the pursuit of the perpetrators of crime: both places and times will be significant here
- the nature of the crimes and the criminals, the criminals' motives and actions
- the inclusion of violence, murder, theft, betrayal
- the detection of the criminal and the investigation that leads to his or her capture or punishment
- how far there is a moral purpose and restoration of order
- guilt and remorse, confession and the desire for forgiveness
- the creation of the criminal and their nemesis, the typical detective hero
- the sense that there will be a resolution and the criminal will be punished
- the victims of crime and the inclusion of suffering
- the central motifs of love, money, danger and death
- punishment, justice, retribution, injustice, accusation, the legal system, criminal trials and courtroom dramas, imprisonment, death
- the structural patterning of the text as it moves through a series of crises to some sense of order
- the specific focus on plotting
- the way that language is used in the world that is created; there may be use of a criminal register, legal register, police register
- the way that crime writing is used to comment on society, particularly the representation of society at particular historical periods
- ultimately, how crime stories affect audiences and readers, creating suspense, repugnance, excitement and relief.

Students study **three** texts from the following list: **one** post-2000 prose text, **one** pre-1900 poetry text and **one** further text.

Author	Text	Time period
Kate Atkinson	<i>When Will There Be Good News?</i>	Post-2000
Agatha Christie	<i>The Murder of Roger Ackroyd</i>	
Samuel Taylor Coleridge	<i>The Rime of the Ancient Mariner</i>	Pre-1900
George Crabbe, Robert Browning and Oscar Wilde	'Peter Grimes', 'The Laboratory', 'My Last Duchess', 'Porphyria's Lover', 'The Ballad of Reading Gaol'	Pre-1900
Charles Dickens	<i>Oliver Twist</i>	Pre-1900
Graham Greene	<i>Brighton Rock</i>	
Ian McEwan	<i>Atonement</i>	Post-2000
William Shakespeare	<i>Hamlet</i>	Pre-1900

We do not expect to change texts within the first five years of the specification. However, texts will be reviewed each year starting in September 2017 and we will give at least nine months' notice of any changes prior to first teaching of a two year course. The criteria for changing texts will be where a text becomes unavailable or where we can no longer use it in a question paper. Notice of any change will be communicated via our exam bulletins and aqa.org.uk/english